



OMG!

❤️ 2.3K

I CAN'T LOOK AWAY

👁️ 8.7K

THIS IS INSANE

😱 6.1K



KEEP THE DRAMA

❤️ 9.4K



TEAM CHAOS

❤️ 7.2K

WHO CAN YOU TRUST?

👤 5.8K

BURN IT DOWN

❤️ 9.1K



MORE DRAMA

👤 8.2K

LIVING HELL

SEASON TWO

EIGHT STRANGERS, ONE HOUSE,
AND THE CROWD'S CHAOS.



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CHAPTER 1

Rock Hard Flips the Couch

The living room was finally quiet enough to hear the fake fireplace tick as it cooled - until the couch made that ugly, mechanical groan like it was waking up pissed.

Bree had just tucked Mr. Whiskers onto the armrest where he always sat, like the world could be managed if you gave it the right chair. The room still looked staged for cameras: clean lines, soft throw pillows, a coffee table polished like it had never held a spilled drink in its life. Then the lights over the ceiling track flickered once, Jenna's voice crackled through the house speakers like a live wire - no greeting, just timing.

"Donation triggered."

The couch flipped.

Not slow. Not graceful. The whole thing lurched up from the floor on hidden hinges, pivoted, and slammed down again with a slap of fabric against wood. One second Bree was watching it as a thing that belonged to the set, the next she was watching it as a weapon. Her stomach dropped; her sneakers skidded on the smooth patch where the couch had been. Mr. Whiskers went sliding, his tiny paws flailing against nothing.

"Hey - hey, no, no, no," Bree hissed, dropping to catch him. Her fingers caught fur and stuffing before he could fall into the gap the couch had opened, but the force of the flip still rocked her wrist. The room smelled like fresh synthetic foam and dust kicked up from beneath the cushions. Somewhere behind the wall, something clanged - metal on metal - like the house was laughing.

A couple of footsteps thundered in the hallway. People were already reacting, already scrambling with that first-day panic that pretends it's confidence.

Phil's voice boomed from nowhere, too cheerful for how wrong the room felt. "Ladies and gentlemen, degenerates and insomniacs - welcome to the Living Hell experience!"

Bree didn't look at the camera. She looked at Mr. Whiskers, because he was her anchor and her excuse. She tucked him into the crook of her elbow and stood, keeping her body between the stuffed animal and the mess of furniture. The living room now had a new geometry: the couch sideways like a tipped boat, the coffee table shifted half an inch, the path to the stairs partially blocked by a dark seam where the floor didn't quite meet.

"Okay," Bree muttered, as if the room could be reasoned with. "We're fine. We're fine."

Mr. Whiskers stared up at her with that stitched, judgemental face. Bree felt stupid for talking to him in a house full of strangers, but the alternative was letting her nerves take the wheel. She'd spent her whole life reading animals and signals - ears, posture, the way a body holds tension before it bolts. This was the same thing, only the tension had springs.

Darla arrived in the living room like she'd always owned the hazard. Her eyes went straight to the couch, then straight to Bree's hands.

"Cute," Darla said, voice sharp as a paper cut. "You're hugging your stuffy like that's gonna stop the house from trying to eat your ankles."

Bree tightened her grip on Mr. Whiskers. "I'm not - he's just - he gets scared."

Darla's mouth twisted. "So do I. I just don't carry it around like a pet."

Bree had wanted, in the minutes since the tour ended, to find her corner of normal - something safe, something hers. She'd pictured the living room as a place where she could talk quietly, settle Mr. Whiskers, and keep her head down while alliances

formed. She'd imagined a slow burn: learn the rules, learn the people, don't make enemies before you even know what enemies cost.

Now the rules were on her floor in the form of a flipped couch and a widening gap that hadn't been there a second ago. The house felt warmer, almost feverish, like it was processing the donation and punishing anyone who moved too fast.

From somewhere near the kitchen, Jerome's laugh came out too loud, like he was trying to convince himself he wasn't rattled. "The couch did what?"

"Flipped," someone else snapped. Bree didn't recognize the voice, but the tone belonged to a person who wanted their fear to sound like anger.

Darla stepped closer, toe first, testing the floor like she was hunting for the exact spot it would betray her. She didn't look at Mr. Whiskers again, but her presence made Bree feel exposed - like the stuffed animal wasn't the only thing being evaluated.

Then Rock Hard - because Phil had said the name earlier in the tour and the house had repeated it like a dare - made another sound.

Not a flip. A low, grinding hum beneath the floor, the kind of noise that didn't belong to furniture. Bree felt it through her soles, a vibration that made her teeth want to click together. Her skin prickled.

Mr. Whiskers' stitched ear pressed into her sleeve as Bree backed toward the far side of the room, away from the couch's new position. She kept her balance carefully, heel to toe, like she was walking a skittish dog across ice. The living room's clean lines were gone; now it was a maze designed by someone who didn't care if you sprained your ankle for the entertainment value.

Jenna's voice crackled again from the ceiling speakers, crisp and delighted in a way that made Bree's stomach twist. "Cameras are live."

Bree didn't see Jenna, but she felt the control room on her skin anyway. The house was suddenly too aware of itself.

Phil's voice threaded through the room, louder than the hum. "Oh, we've got momentum tonight."

Bree swallowed. Momentum for who? For the audience. For the donation system. For the people who could afford to make someone else pay.

The first donation had gone live like a match tossed into dry grass. Bree had wanted to stay steady, keep Mr. Whiskers calm, keep herself from being the first person to break. But the couch had flipped on a whim, and now every sound in the room felt like it came with a price tag.

Darla noticed Bree's movement. Her gaze tracked the way Bree angled her body toward the hallway leading to the stairs.

"Where you going?" Darla asked.

Bree forced her voice to stay level. "Nowhere. Just... getting my footing."

Darla laughed once. "That's funny. I thought you were trying to win."

Bree stared at the gap near the stairs. The floor seam looked like a crack waiting for a heel. She could almost hear the invisible mechanics under it, the secret language of hinges and motors.

She wanted to stay in the living room - because it was where people were, where conversation could happen, where she could build a low-drama alliance before anyone decided she was weak. But safety was acting like a cruel option, like the house was daring her to prove she could handle danger by walking right into it.

Mr. Whiskers' fur was warm from her body heat. Bree pictured his panic - imagined it, because animals always made sense when you listened. So Bree listened. She listened to her own fear, the way it climbed her throat when Darla watched her too closely.

Darla stepped in front of her, blocking part of the path. "Don't pretend you don't see what this is. The audience is testing us."

Bree's jaw tightened. "They're messing with us."

"Same thing," Darla said, and the way she said it - like she was proud of the cruelty - made Bree's stomach sink harder than the couch had.

Jerome's voice cut in from the other side of the room. "Hey, Darla, you okay?"

Darla didn't turn. "Fine."

Jerome's boots scraped the floor as he moved closer, careful but still smiling like he had a plan. Bree recognized the type: people who acted like danger was a challenge instead of an injury waiting to happen. Jerome's hands were empty, but the way he looked at the couch suggested he wanted to fix it, tame it, make it useful again.

"Maybe we should - " he started.

Phil's voice surged again, cutting off whatever Jerome meant to do. "Viewer control is live! Keep moving, people. We love a good scramble."

Bree winced at the word scramble like it was a physical shove. The hum under the floor deepened for a second, then eased, like the house had swallowed its own threat and was ready to spit it out again.

Darla's attention sharpened. "Did you hear that?"

Bree did. The house didn't just flip furniture; it signaled. It teased. It watched who froze and who adapted. Darla probably knew the game already, or she guessed it fast. Bree had spent her life adapting to animals; she hadn't expected the world to be an animal too, with teeth.

Mr. Whiskers' little stitched face felt heavier in Bree's arm. She couldn't afford to look rattled - couldn't afford to be the first to cry or the first to blame someone else and start a war. She needed calm. She needed to keep him close, because calm traveled through routine.

So Bree made a decision that tasted like risk.

She shifted her weight, stepped around Darla's blocked line, and moved toward the hallway - toward the stairs. Not running. Not flailing. Just fast enough to claim motion before the house claimed it for her.

Darla's eyes widened, just a fraction. "Oh, you're leaving the living room."

"I'm not leaving," Bree said, and hated how defensive it sounded. "I'm just - going where it's safer."

Darla's smile turned mean. "Safer? The audience can flip the stairs, Bree."

Bree's name landed like a hook. Darla knew it - knew it already. That meant Darla had been watching, listening, mapping names to weaknesses.

Bree tightened her grip on Mr. Whiskers. "Then I'll be quicker."

She stepped again, toward the edge of the room where the seam near the stairs cut across the floor like a warning. Her heel hovered for a beat, then touched down - solid, for now. The hum beneath the boards returned, lower than before, like the house was deciding whether she was worth punishing.

Behind her, Darla moved too, close enough that Bree could feel her attention like heat. Darla didn't block her this time; she paced beside her, matching her speed like a predator learning the rhythm of prey.

Jerome's footsteps followed, and Hugh and Vince's voices tangled in the background - someone swearing, someone laughing too hard. Bree didn't catch the words; she caught the energy. The house was swallowing everyone's comfort.

Halfway to the stairs, the living room gave another mechanical cough.

This one wasn't a flip. It was a shift - subtle, like a trap resetting itself. The couch moved a few inches with a wet, grinding thunk, and the gap near the stairs widened in response, exposing the darker underside of the floor where cables and metal hid. Bree's stomach lurched, and she had to yank her foot back to keep from stepping into it.

Mr. Whiskers bumped her elbow, his fur brushing her skin. Bree hissed a breath through her teeth and adjusted her footing with a sharp, careful step.

Darla caught the moment Bree almost fell. Her eyes gleamed, like she'd been waiting all day for proof Bree wasn't as steady as she pretended.

"See?" Darla said softly. "Not safe at all."

Bree forced herself not to look back. She moved toward the stairs in small, deliberate steps, trying to keep the panic from turning her muscles into jelly. Her heart hammered anyway, loud enough that she could feel it in her throat.

Then, just as her hand brushed the stair rail, the house speakers crackled again - Jenna's crisp voice, the kind that sounded like she was reading a menu.

"Donation request received."

Bree froze for half a second, because the words meant there was no pause button. The audience could do it again at any moment. Mr. Whiskers' stitched eyes stared toward the stairwell like he could see the future and hated it.

Phil's voice followed, warm with menace. "Let's see what the house does next."

Darla leaned in, close enough that Bree could smell her - sweet perfume over something sharper, like impatience. "If you fall, Bree," Darla said, "I'm not helping you."

Bree looked at her hand on the rail. Looked at the stairs that suddenly felt too steep and too close to a mechanism that could lurch at any time. She wanted to stay composed, wanted to keep Mr. Whiskers calm, wanted to pretend she'd chosen this path.

But the first couch flip had already stripped away her security, and Darla's scrutiny was already pinning Bree in place.

Bree took one more step - then another - moving rooms the hard way, forced forward by danger and watched by the girl who treated vulnerability like entertainment. Behind

her, the living room settled into its new angles, waiting for the next donation to turn comfort into collateral.

CHAPTER 2

Mr. Whiskers Picks a Quiet Ally

The hallway outside the bedrooms smelled like warm dust and fresh paint that couldn't decide whether it wanted to dry. Bree kept one hand on the wall as she walked - actually walked - because her balance was still negotiating with the couch flip like it had been personally offended.

Mr. Whiskers rode in the crook of her arm, his stitched whiskers brushing her sleeve. The little guy felt heavier than he had downstairs, not because he'd changed, but because Bree had. Her throat was tight from holding her face still while Darla watched her like a hawk that already knew where the mouse would trip.

"You're hard to ignore," Darla said, voice light and sharp, like she'd sharpened it on a knife and then pretended it was candy. She leaned against the opposite wall with the kind of casual that didn't match the way her eyes tracked Bree's every movement. "You keep getting dragged into places."

"I'm fine," Bree said, and heard how thin it came out. Fine was a lie she'd been telling stuffed animals for years, and apparently the house liked recycling it.

Darla's smile didn't reach her eyes. "No, you're not. That couch did a whole stunt show for strangers and you still act like the floor is your friend."

Bree didn't have a comeback ready. She had a plan - quiet, low-drama, alliances that didn't require loud choices. She wanted a pocket of calm upstairs for tonight, for Mr. Whiskers to be more than an accessory. She wanted to stop feeling like every comfort she brought into the light got turned into bait.

But upstairs, Darla's attention was a spotlight with teeth.

Somewhere below them, the house made a wet, metal click, like a lock turning in a throat. Bree flinched anyway, shoulders bunching. Mr. Whiskers' ear pressed into her ribs, soft and reassuring in a way that made her angry at herself for needing it.

Darla pushed off the wall. The hallway carpet muffled her steps, and it still sounded too loud. "Where's your buddy now? Your little therapy blanket's not doing much, is it?"

"It's Mr. Whiskers," Bree said, sharper than she meant. She swallowed, forced her voice back into something controlled. "And he's - he's just - "

"Comfort," Darla finished, like it tasted bad. "That's what you're selling. Comfort." She stepped closer, crowding Bree's space until Bree could feel the heat of her body through the thin fabric of her own shirt. "People like you think staying quiet makes you safe."

The hallway felt narrower with every word. Bree's heartbeat didn't care about strategy. It just kept climbing.

"I don't want trouble," Bree said, and it was the truest thing she'd said all night.

Darla laughed once, short. "Everybody says that right before they get to pick who they betray. You're not special, Bree. You're just... convenient."

Bree could've tried to fold herself smaller. She'd done that before - at jobs, in rooms with loud opinions, in the spaces where people decided what kind of person you were. But she'd already learned tonight that neutrality didn't read as harmless to the house. It read as available.

Mr. Whiskers' stitched face stared up at her like he was daring her to act like she had a spine.

A door down the hall opened with a groan of hinges, and a slice of warm air spilled out. Charcoal and grilling smoke drifted through the crack, and with it came Jerome's laugh - half exhausted, half relieved, like he'd been running on grief and caffeine.

Jerome stepped into the hall holding a spatula like it was a staff. His grill, Charlene, wasn't visible, but the smell of her clung to him - grease warmed to the edge of sweet. He looked from Bree to Darla and immediately adopted the posture of someone trying to keep fire from spreading.

"Yo," Jerome said, voice low. His eyes flicked to Mr. Whiskers. "You good?"

Bree's relief hit so hard it almost made her dizzy. Jerome was new and already familiar in the way people got when they had something real to anchor them. She'd heard the others' introductions earlier - Portland, stuffed animal, comfort, Mr. Whiskers - and she'd watched Darla's eye-roll like it was a sport. Jerome, though... Jerome seemed like he'd been learning to hold himself together by force.

Bree took a breath that didn't fix anything but steadied her. "I'm - yeah. I'm okay."

Darla's gaze snapped to Jerome. "Oh, look. The pitmaster's roaming. You lost something?"

Jerome didn't rise to it. He kept his spatula angled down, not threatening. "I was just checking on the grill situation. Charlene was mad earlier."

"Charlene," Darla repeated, like the name was cute enough to mock. She turned back to Bree. "You're collecting allies now?"

Bree felt the words before she spoke them. "Not collecting. Just... staying out of the way."

Jerome's expression tightened at the corner of his mouth. "Staying out of the way doesn't mean you gotta let people step on you."

That should've been comforting. Instead, it made Bree's stomach drop. Darla would hear it as a challenge. Darla would hear it as weakness - someone giving permission for conflict.

Darla stepped between Bree and Jerome like she owned the hallway. "Jerome," she said, sweet as syrup over something rotten. "Don't be fooled. She's playing the

comfort angle. Quiet Bree. Soft Bree. Stuffed animal Bree.” Her eyes lingered on Mr. Whiskers. “That’s not protection. That’s manipulation.”

Bree’s hands tightened around Mr. Whiskers until the plush shifted in her grip. The hallway heat rose, and she felt the urge to defend herself explode out of her like a sneeze she couldn’t stop.

“I’m not manipulating you,” Bree said.

Darla’s smile sharpened. “Then why are you always with him? Why’s your whole personality a stuffed animal?”

Jerome’s eyes narrowed, and Bree could see the moment his grief and his patience wrestled for the steering wheel. He stared at Darla like he was deciding whether this was worth the burn.

“Hey,” Jerome said, voice firmer now. “Leave her alone.”

Darla’s laugh returned, louder this time. “You think telling me to ‘leave her alone’ is gonna fix something? This is a competition, Jerome. People pick sides. People get targeted. She picked comfort. That means she gets to be a target.”

Bree swallowed again. She could feel the internal war starting - her instinct to retreat, to smooth everything over with kindness, to make herself smaller so nobody noticed her edges. But the house had already shown her what happened to soft things under pressure.

Mr. Whiskers’ ear pressed against her palm, and Bree suddenly understood she needed a different kind of quiet. Not silence. Boundaries.

She lifted her chin. “Jerome,” she said, keeping her voice steady, “I don’t want you in my fight. I don’t want one at all.”

Jerome blinked at that, like he hadn’t expected her to speak like she had control over her choices.

Bree continued, the words coming faster because she'd decided. "But I also don't want Darla deciding what I am in front of you. If she's going to label me, you don't have to join in."

Darla's eyes widened a fraction - annoyance, not surprise. She'd been waiting for Bree to crumble. Bree wasn't crumbling.

Jerome looked between them, and Bree watched him do the math: Darla's aggression versus Bree's need for safety, his own grief versus the risk of getting pulled into a house-wide fight.

Then Jerome exhaled, slow. "Fine," he said. "No fight. Not with you."

Bree's chest loosened, breath coming out in a shaky rush. That was what she wanted: a low-drama pact that kept her and Mr. Whiskers out of the crossfire overnight.

Darla's mouth curled. "A pact? Really? You're gonna make deals in hallways now?"

Jerome didn't look away from Bree when he answered. "She's not doing anything to you. So stop acting like she is."

Darla's stare snapped back to Jerome, and her voice went colder. "I'm not acting. I'm reading the room."

The hallway lights flickered once - subtle, like a warning tap. Bree felt it in her teeth. The house liked timing its scares to the moment people got comfortable.

From somewhere nearby, a faint electronic buzz threaded through the air. Bree's skin prickled. The TTS system wasn't supposed to be a background hum; it was supposed to erupt with consequences. Tonight it had already flipped the couch downstairs like the house was laughing.

Darla noticed Bree noticing. Her lips parted, and for a second Bree thought she might back off.

Instead, Darla lifted her chin and spoke louder, projecting her words down the hall like she was aiming them at an unseen camera. "Bree's comfort strategy is manipulation. She's using him to look harmless."

Jerome's face changed - one part confusion, one part irritation. "Stop."

Bree's stomach dropped through the floor. That wasn't just an accusation. It was a claim. Darla was planting a narrative in the open, making it harder for Bree to retract without looking guilty.

Bree tightened her grip on Mr. Whiskers and tried to keep her voice calm. "Jerome, she's not - "

Darla cut in, eyes bright with victory. "Tell him. Explain how your stuffed animal is a shield. Explain why you need a quiet ally and you pick the one guy who's already sad."

Jerome went still, spatula unmoving. The smell of grilling smoke turned suddenly sharp, like the air had been scorched. Bree could see the exact place Darla's words landed: on the bruise Jerome carried around his chest, the one he didn't talk about but Charlene helped him hold.

Bree shouldn't have felt powerless. She should've expected it. Darla's win-first mindset turned neutrality into a target, and now Darla had politicized Bree's need for safety into something ugly.

Bree made herself move. If she stayed frozen, Darla would write the scene for her. Bree stepped closer to Jerome, not touching him, just closing the distance enough that Darla couldn't pretend this was just Bree being "cute."

"Jerome," Bree said quietly, "I'm not using you. I'm asking you to keep the hall calm. That's it."

Jerome's throat bobbed. He looked at Mr. Whiskers again, and something softened in his eyes. "Okay," he said, but his voice carried the weight of a promise he didn't want to make and couldn't avoid now. "I can do calm."

Darla's grin returned, thin and satisfied. "Great. Then you can be calm while she's manipulating everyone with her comfort act."

Jerome's jaw flexed. "Darla - "

The electronic buzz sharpened. The house, restless, waited for the next donation like it was hungry.

Bree felt the quiet pact settle between her and Jerome, fragile but real. She'd gotten something durable - an alliance axis, as solid as her stuffed animal could be against a house that loved chaos. But Darla had already made it public. She'd turned Bree's protection into a storyline.

Bree didn't know how to fight a narrative without breaking it - and she didn't want to break.

She just needed one night. One. Then she could figure out how to survive tomorrow.

In the hallway's flickering light, Darla leaned back like she'd already cashed the check. Jerome stayed between Bree and the trouble, Charlene's smoky warmth clinging to him.

And Bree - plush in her arms, anger in her chest - stood her ground while the house hummed, already listening for the next message to drop.

CHAPTER 3

Darla Claims the Corner Room

“**C**orner room’s mine,” Darla said, like she was announcing a rule instead of making a promise. The hallway light behind her buzzed and stuttered, throwing jerky shadows over the carpet runner. Jerome’s shoulders stayed square in front of Bree, Charlene’s heat - smoky and sweet - radiating off him like a warning flare.

Bree clutched Mr. Whiskers to her chest, her fingers tight enough that the fabric looked ready to crease. She didn’t argue; she watched Darla the way she’d watch a dog that could either cuddle or bite. “We’re... trying to keep it calm,” Bree said, voice low, careful. “Just for tonight.”

Darla’s mouth curled. “Tonight is the part everybody lies about.” She angled her chin toward the doorway at the end of the hall, the one that led into the corner bedroom. The door looked ordinary - cheap wood, scuffed paint, a handle that had been grabbed too many times already - but Darla moved like she’d already been assigned it by fate and a payment confirmation. “That room. Corner. My corner.”

Jerome shifted, not stepping away from Bree, but stepping toward the space between them. His hands were open, palms out, like he was holding back a flame with sheer will. “Darla,” he said, slower than his usual Chicago drawl, “we just got Bree through the couch nonsense. We’re not doing another - ”

“Another what?” Darla snapped. “Another negotiation? Another bedtime story?” She pointed a finger at the corner bedroom door, then at Bree’s plush bundle. “I’m not asking, Jerome. I’m taking. Everybody’s been acting like the house decides. The house doesn’t decide. People do.”

Bree's eyes flicked toward the door, then to the flicker of light, then back to Darla. The hallway smelled like old carpet and whatever Charlene had been cooking earlier - smoke pressed into the air so thick it clung to the back of Darla's throat. The sound of it all sat under everything: the faint hum of the house, the distant click of mechanisms, like it was listening for the next donation.

Darla leaned in close enough that Bree could feel her heat. "Corner room," she repeated. "Now."

Bree's jaw tightened. She was the type who could swallow a threat and pretend it was just air temperature, but her grip on Mr. Whiskers betrayed her. The stuffed animal's stitched face seemed to stare through Darla's insistence, as if the silence could be negotiated into safety.

Jerome exhaled through his nose. "Bree, you okay?" he asked, without turning his body away from Darla.

"I'm okay," Bree said, and the lie was obvious even to herself. She looked at Jerome, then at the door. "I can - I can make space."

Darla heard it anyway. "Make space," she echoed, and laughter came out sharp, almost delighted. "That's cute. You're volunteering."

Before Bree could answer, the hallway door at the other end clicked - someone else shifting, someone else moving - and the sound carried like a drumbeat. Darla's eyes tracked toward it automatically, like she expected the house to open its mouth again.

It didn't open. It just waited.

That waiting was what made the next sound land.

Footsteps, heavier than the others, came down the hall and stopped just outside the corner bedroom threshold. A voice followed - low, unhurried, annoyed in a way that didn't need permission.

"Hold up."

Darla didn't turn her back on Bree and Jerome; she turned just enough to see who'd dared to interrupt her. A boy stood there with the posture of someone who'd never been told "no" and believed it was a design flaw. His shoulders were wide, his expression flat, and he looked at the corner bedroom door like it had personally wronged him.

"Who are you?" Darla asked, even though she knew. The show had already plastered everyone's name in their heads like stickers.

He didn't flinch. "Marcus," he said. "And I'm not sleeping in a corner you claim like you're the landlord."

Jerome's grill-charm - Charlene's smoky warmth - flickered with irritation. "Darla's just - " he started.

"Just what?" Marcus cut in, eyes narrowing. "Just taking? Cool. But here's the thing. We're not doing territory the way adults do it in playgrounds." He said "adults" like it tasted funny. "We're doing it fair."

Darla blinked once. The hallway light buzzed again, then stuttered, and for a second the corner bedroom door looked like a mouth in the dark, ready to swallow whoever stepped too close.

Fair.

Darla's temper didn't rise like a wave. It surged like a fire catching paper. She could feel it in her hands, in the way her fingers wanted to curl into something that could grab. "Fair?" she repeated, voice tight. "You want fair, Marcus? You're gonna get fair. You can sleep wherever the house flips you."

Marcus didn't laugh. That was the problem. He didn't look scared or impressed. He looked annoyed that she'd made the world sound like a joke.

"I'm not letting you set the rules," Marcus said. "Not before tomorrow's challenge. Bed rotation. I heard people talking. I'm not getting shoved into some leftover spot

because you're - " His eyes flicked to Bree's stuffed animal, then to Jerome's place in the doorway. " - because you're trying to own the night."

Darla's throat went dry. She had wanted the corner room because it was hers - because it backed into the hallway where she could see who came and went; because it made a clean boundary; because it was the one space in the house that felt like it could be controlled. She'd pictured the night quieting down after the couch chaos, pictured Bree and her little stuffed-animal comfort strategy staying out of her way.

But Marcus wasn't asking. He was demanding.

And demands, Darla knew, were what made the house unpredictable.

She stepped toward the threshold, stopping short of crossing it. "You don't get to come in here and tell me what tomorrow looks like," she said. "I'm taking the corner. That's the rule for tonight."

Marcus leaned slightly forward. "Tonight doesn't matter if tomorrow's going to be rigged. You can't lock a room and pretend it's not going to decide who's comfortable when the challenge starts."

Jerome's voice turned careful, not soft. "Marcus, she's fifteen - "

Darla's head snapped toward him. "Don't," she warned.

Jerome shut his mouth and looked away for half a beat, like he'd swallowed something sharp. Charlene's grill-smoke scent thickened as he shifted, stubborn warmth in a cold hallway.

Bree stood still, eyes wide, Mr. Whiskers pressed to her chest like a life vest. She didn't speak, but her breathing got shallow, and Darla could hear it - small, quick - under the house hum.

That was when Darla realized the corner-room takeover wasn't just a room. It was a stage.

The house would use it. Viewers would use it. People would use it.

Darla's teeth ground. She wanted to shove Marcus back out of the hallway and lock the door behind him. She wanted to make Bree watch and Jerome flinch and prove that she wasn't someone to push aside.

But the way Marcus stood there - calm, stubborn, refusing to be managed - made Darla feel something she hated more than losing.

She felt timed.

Like the house had already started counting down toward a flip, toward a message, toward the moment when her "rule for tonight" would become somebody else's leverage.

The hallway light flickered again, brighter this time, and with it came a faint click from somewhere inside the walls. The sound was subtle, but Darla's body reacted like she'd felt it in her bones.

She couldn't let the corner room become a public fight that lasted all night. She couldn't let Marcus turn her authority into content.

So she made a choice that tasted like metal.

"Fine," Darla said, and the word came out too fast, too sharp. "Bed rotation tomorrow. You want fair? You get a fair discussion. But right now - right now - you move out of the doorway."

Marcus stared at her. "No."

Darla's eyes widened. "No?"

"No," Marcus repeated, slower, like he was teaching a lesson he didn't think she deserved. "If you're taking the corner, you can do it. But I'm not leaving the doorway until you agree to rotation rules. I'm not doing this where you get to dictate and we all just... accept."

Bree swallowed. Her voice came out shaky. "Marcus, maybe - maybe we can talk later. Darla's trying to - "

Darla jerked her gaze to Bree. "Don't," she snapped, then caught herself. Her anger had always been easy, like breathing. It was the control that was hard. "Bree. You can talk. But you don't get to decide this."

Bree flinched, and Mr. Whiskers pressed into her chest looked suddenly too small for the space it was meant to protect.

Jerome stepped forward, hands lifting again, trying to wedge himself between the explosion and the people. "Marcus, listen," he said. "Charlene and I - we can - "

"Charlene?" Marcus asked, eyes shifting to Jerome's side like he'd only now noticed there was a whole person attached to the smoke.

Jerome's face tightened. "My grill," he said, the words clipped. "Not that it matters."

Marcus looked at Darla again. "It matters," he said. "Because you're all acting like comfort is something you get to trade. Like tomorrow's challenge is a favor you can ask for."

Darla's temper surged again, but this time she grabbed it by the throat and held it. She could feel the house listening. She could feel Jenna somewhere in the control room, camera eyes fixed, waiting for the moment Darla's voice broke.

She forced herself to speak calmly, which was worse than yelling.

"Here's what's happening," Darla said, and her words sounded like a contract she didn't want to sign. "The corner room is mine tonight. We're not sleeping in the hallway. You want bed rotation tomorrow? We do it tomorrow, with everybody watching. Fair. You get your fair."

Marcus's expression stayed stubborn, but his eyes flicked briefly toward Bree and Jerome, and the corner bedroom door behind Darla. For a moment, he looked like he

was doing math - calculating how much fight he could afford before the house itself decided to intervene.

Then he finally exhaled. "Okay," he said. "But you agree now. Not later. Now."

Darla's mouth opened, ready to refuse, ready to spit out a dozen reasons why she didn't owe him anything.

Then the hallway buzzed - harder this time - and a soft mechanical whirr echoed from the walls. The sound didn't mean a flip yet, but it carried the threat of one. The house was too aware, too eager, like it smelled drama and wanted to bottle it.

Darla hated that the house could push them around without touching them.

Hated it so much she almost let Marcus win just to prove it couldn't.

Instead, she did the thing that made her feel sick and powerful at the same time.

She nodded once, sharp as a gavel. "Tomorrow," she said. "Bed rotation. Fair. Everybody watches."

Marcus's lips pressed together. "Good."

Jerome's shoulders loosened a fraction, like he'd been holding his breath since the couch flip. Bree's breathing slowed, the sharpness easing just enough that Mr. Whiskers didn't look like it was being crushed.

Darla stepped forward and grabbed the corner bedroom door handle. The metal was cold under her palm, and the door resisted for a second - paint stuck to paint, like the house didn't want to be easy. Then it gave with a low scrape.

She pulled it open.

The room smelled like dust and old detergent, faintly warmed by the house's constant hum. A narrow bed sat along the far wall. The corner space felt tight but clean, and

when Darla looked over her shoulder, she could see the doorway framing the hallway like a camera shot meant to catch trouble.

She was in.

She was claiming.

She could almost feel the next day's chaos already rehearsing itself.

Marcus stayed in the doorway behind her, not fully blocking it anymore, but refusing to step back into the hallway like he'd agreed to anything just to be polite. He looked at her with a stubbornness that didn't care about her age, her temper, or her right to the corner.

"You're done tonight," he said.

Darla's laugh came out once, a rough bark. "Yeah," she said. "I'm done. For now."

He nodded like he'd expected that answer. Then he added, voice low enough that Bree and Jerome had to strain to hear, "Tomorrow we settle it. No tricks."

Darla stared at him from the threshold, the room's thin air cooling her cheeks. The hallway light behind them flickered again, casting Marcus in and out of shadow like the house couldn't decide whether he was a problem or a prop.

"Tomorrow," Darla repeated.

Bree shifted in the hallway, Mr. Whiskers still tucked to her chest. She looked at Darla with something that might've been relief, or maybe guilt for being relieved. Jerome stood beside her, Charlene's smoky warmth still clinging, but his eyes kept darting back to Marcus like he didn't trust him.

Darla finally stepped all the way inside and shut the corner bedroom door with enough force to make the sound travel through the wood. The click of it felt final in her bones.

For half a breath, silence held.

Then, from the other side of the door, Marcus's voice carried - flat, insistent. "Fair rotation, Darla. Don't forget."

Darla leaned her forehead against the cold door panel, eyes shut. The house hummed in the walls like a giant appliance waiting to be turned on. Somewhere nearby, Charlene's smoke faded into the background. Bree's footsteps shifted away down the hall.

And Darla stood there with the corner room she wanted - her territory, her claim - while knowing the cost had already been paid.

Not with blood.

With time.

With tomorrow.

CHAPTER 4

Kenny Counts Seventeen Microphones

Kenny Alvarez could hear the house thinking.

Not with words - nothing in LIVING HELL ever bothered with that - but with the tiny clicks inside the walls, the soft whirl of a motor switching routes, the faint hiss of air vents changing pressure like the place had lungs. Down the bathroom corridor, the tile floors stayed cold under his socks, and every time he shifted his weight, the ceiling lights trembled once, twice, like they were listening for permission.

He kept his voice low anyway. "Okay," he murmured, not to anyone in particular, as if the microphones might appreciate manners. His fingers hovered near the doorframe where the paint was slightly scuffed - fresh scuff marks left by other contestants sprinting away from day-one chaos. Bree had already been forced to move rooms the hard way earlier, Mr. Whiskers tucked close like a portable life raft. Darla had claimed the corner room with her forehead on the cold panel like she was staking land.

Kenny stared at the small grate near the ceiling. Seventeen microphones, he'd counted - because of course he had. He'd counted them the same way other people counted sheep: to keep his brain from doing worse math. If the system was as clean as Phil McCracken's confident smile on the main stage, then each mic would capture consistently, route predictably, respond to the TTS donation system in a way you could map.

That was the question burning under his tongue, the one he kept tasting when he swallowed: who controlled the control room, really? Jenna said she was just executing. Phil said the viewers pulled the strings through a state of the art TTS

donation system. But Kenny had watched the house punish people for being curious, like curiosity was a crime with a receipt.

He stepped closer to the grate and angled his face the way he'd practiced. He'd make it simple. He'd test it. He'd force the system to tell the truth by feeding it the smallest possible signal - sound, timing, intent - then see what came back.

What he wanted this scene was stupidly specific: to prove which microphones actually fed the TTS routing, and whether the donations were being relayed to the house as a whole or selectively filtered through a control logic that chose targets.

He didn't want a theory. He wanted an answer he could write down on the inside of his wrist with a pen he'd stolen from someone's "temporarily misplaced" drawer. He wanted a pattern so sharp it could cut the show open.

The trouble arrived wearing the same face as the house.

The corridor smelled like bleach that had been used too hard - sharp enough to sting the back of his throat. The air was dry, chilled, and every sound came back wrong: his breath sounded louder than it should've, his shoes too squeaky, the faint buzz of electronics sitting in the walls like a trapped insect.

Kenny took a breath, then spoke again - clear, steady. "Test. Microphone check."

He waited for the response that always came after an input. In this place, the system didn't ignore data. It reacted, sometimes with a couch flip, sometimes with a lock clicking into place, sometimes with a punishment that felt personal even when it couldn't possibly be.

Nothing happened.

For three heartbeats, he let himself believe he'd gotten away with it. Then, somewhere deeper in the house, a door slammed. Not the bathroom corridor door - somewhere else, a hard metallic bang that made the tile vibrate under his heel. A second later, the hallway lights flickered and steadied like a camera finding focus.

Kenny's stomach tightened. "No," he whispered, because the house never punished him for nothing. The system had heard him. It had simply decided the consequence belonged to someone else.

He backed up toward the nearest wall and tried again, quieter this time. "Coordinates," he said, and tapped the tile twice with his knuckle. He'd heard about people mapping access points in old buildings. He didn't need permission. He needed correlation.

A click echoed overhead, crisp and wrong, like the grate had swallowed his sound and turned it into a command.

The bathroom corridor door behind him unlocked with a soft chime - then swung open into a draft so cold it raised goosebumps on his arms. Kenny spun, half-ready to dodge, and saw nothing but the empty space beyond the threshold.

Then the scent hit him: scorched plastic.

Somewhere in the house, an appliance kicked too fast. A low rumble rolled through the vents like a train passing under the floor. Kenny's throat went dry. The system wasn't just listening; it was routing his input into a sequence, and it was learning how to keep him confused.

He tried to hold on to logic anyway. Map the microphones, then infer the routing. That was all. That was safe. That was - A voice carried down the corridor, bright and amused, like a camera had found a new toy.

"Hey, Kenny."

Darla's tone snapped through the air before her footsteps did. She came into view at the far end of the hall, fifteen and sharp as a knife someone had sharpened on a joke. Her eyes flicked over him, then to the ceiling grate. She smiled like she'd just found the answer to a question she hadn't asked out loud.

Kenny froze. His hands tingled, as if the air itself was transmitting heat. "What are you doing?"

Darla lifted her chin toward the ceiling. "You counting again?"

He didn't like how quickly she'd read his mood. He didn't like that the house had made his testing loud enough for her to notice. "I'm not - "

"Oh, you are." Darla stepped closer, the soles of her shoes making a soft slap on tile. She didn't touch him, but she didn't have to. Her presence pulled the air tighter around his ribs. "You're the only one who acts like the walls owe you an explanation."

Kenny swallowed bleach and fear. "I'm figuring out how the system works."

Darla's laugh came out thin. "The system works. People just don't."

Kenny turned his head slightly, trying to catch any sound changes in the grate's direction. If he could hear which microphone triggered the lock, he could isolate the pattern. If he couldn't - then the system wasn't filtering by microphone at all. It was filtering by intent. By suspicion. By who watched.

He wanted to tell Darla to back off. He wanted to keep his test clean. But the corridor had become a stage, and Darla treated stages like playgrounds.

Before Kenny could answer, the TTS system buzzed - soft at first, then louder, like a phone vibrating inside a wall.

A robotic chime followed. Not from the corridor speaker - this time the sound seemed to come from everywhere at once, as if the house had decided to remove the distance between cause and effect.

Kenny felt his skin tighten. The house didn't just punish randomly. It punished like it had a scoreboard.

Darla's smile widened. "See? It heard you."

Kenny didn't look at her. He looked up again, counting micro-movements in the grate shadows. "What did you do?"

"I didn't do anything." Darla shrugged with exaggerated innocence. "Viewers do stuff. That's the point."

Kenny hated that she was probably right. But hate wasn't evidence.

He tried to run the next test anyway, because that was the whole problem with being the kind of person who needed answers: he couldn't stop when stopping would've been smarter. He leaned toward the grate and spoke a single word, clipped and deliberate.

"Seventeen."

The house responded like it had been waiting for him to say it.

A mechanical whirr started overhead - tiny, fast, and precise. The ceiling grate shifted a fraction of an inch, just enough to let a whisper of air through. Then the corridor lights went dim, not full blackout, but enough to turn his shadow into a threatening shape.

Kenny's breath caught. That wasn't a punishment for speaking. That was a reaction to the number itself. The system wasn't merely capturing audio; it was mapping it.

He felt a rush - then the bottom dropped out of it when the door behind Darla clicked shut.

She didn't move fast enough to stop it. The latch snapped with a sound too final. Darla blinked once, then turned to face the locked corridor door with the expression of someone who'd just lost something she didn't know she valued.

Kenny's heart hammered once - hard, ugly. He hadn't meant for Darla to be trapped. His whole point was mapping microphones, not causing collateral chaos.

But in LIVING HELL, intent didn't matter the way people wanted it to. The system cared about inputs and outcomes. It cared about which route a donation chose. It cared about who got isolated when the show got bored.

Darla's eyes swung back to Kenny, and now there was no amusement in her face. Just focus. "So you **are** doing something," she said, voice low. "You think you're clever."

Kenny stepped back, careful with his feet on the cold tile. "I didn't lock you in."

Darla's mouth tightened. "That's what everyone says right before they get blamed."

The corridor buzzed again, a stronger vibration this time. Kenny felt it in his teeth. Then the sound changed - like the house had selected a different microphone array to amplify.

He heard a faint voice through the corridor speaker this time, muffled, not Jenna's, not Phil's. It sounded like a donation message being read aloud somewhere else in the house, but the timing hit like a cue: the system was routing his test and anyone near it into a loop the viewers could manipulate.

Kenny's thoughts raced. He'd been chasing the cameras, the microphones, the logic. But the house was using people as variables. The minute he tried to isolate microphones, it isolated him by association - then used Darla's anger as the lever.

A third set of footsteps approached from the bedroom doors - he couldn't see who yet, but the pace was familiar. Darla's posture changed instantly, shoulders angling like she expected an audience.

Jerome rounded the corner with Charlene's smoky warmth clinging to him like a secret he didn't want to share. The grill wasn't in his hands, but the smell of charcoal and pepper lingered anyway, proof that grief and fire could live in the same body. His eyes landed on Darla's locked door, then on Kenny's tense stance.

"What did you do?" Jerome asked, not accusing yet - just trying to understand the shape of the trouble.

Darla snapped her gaze to Jerome like she'd been waiting for him to arrive. "He's been poking the house," she said. "Counting microphones like it's a math problem."

Kenny opened his mouth. "I'm not - "

Jerome held up a palm. "Kenny."

Hearing his name like that - calm, familiar - made Kenny want to believe he could still talk his way out. But the house didn't reward calm. It rewarded triggers.

The corridor lights flickered again, and this time the sound overhead shifted into a louder hum, like the microphones were being reconfigured. Kenny could almost feel the system choosing where to listen next.

He made a decision that tasted like metal.

If he couldn't force the house to reveal its pattern cleanly, then he would record it the only way he could: by capturing the evidence before the system hid it behind punishment. He grabbed the edge of the bathroom corridor wall where a cable ran behind a panel - something he'd noticed earlier when the hallway lights flickered and the hum spiked. His fingers found the seam. He pulled.

A soft resistance gave way. He didn't yank - he worked it open carefully, because even if the house wanted chaos, Kenny still wanted data.

Inside, wires sat in a bundle like veins. He found the small port he'd been hunting, the one he'd suspected fed the microphone array. It was small, too small to be obvious to anyone who wasn't looking for it, and it felt wrong in his hand - slick with insulation, cool as if it had been waiting.

Jerome's voice cut in. "Kenny, stop. Don't - "

Kenny shoved a recorder into place - one of the cheap devices he'd scavenged when the couch flipped and people left behind whatever they grabbed in panic. He pressed record with shaking fingers. The red light blinked, stubborn and tiny against the corridor's cold glow.

"Evidence," Kenny said under his breath. "Just evidence."

The TTS buzz hit like a wave. Jenna's control-room adjustments were always behind the scenes - no one down here saw her hands, only the outcomes. But Kenny had started to suspect she wasn't just reacting. She was redirecting. If he could prove the routing was selective, he could prove that the "internet controls everything" line wasn't the whole truth. It was a curtain.

He hit the next test word, sharper, and aimed it toward the open panel.

"Route."

The hum changed. The corridor speaker crackled once, then quieted like it had swallowed a secret. For a breath, the house stopped playing games.

Then Rock Hard decided to show up.

The sound wasn't subtle. A heavy mechanical clank echoed from somewhere behind the bedroom doors, followed by a thud as if something had been dropped onto the floor. Kenny's recorder light flickered - then steadied, as if the device itself was being protected for one cruel moment.

Jerome's eyes widened. "What is that?"

Kenny didn't get to answer. The corridor air went warmer in a sudden patch, like a heat lamp turned on too close to skin. Then Rock Hard's presence filled the hall - metal, weight, and a sense of inevitability. It moved with purpose toward Kenny, blocking the line of sight back to the open panel, blocking the corridor door, blocking escape routes the way a stage prop blocks a camera.

Darla shoved against her locked door, voice rising. "Kenny! Don't touch - "

He backed away, palms up, recorder still in place. "I'm recording - "

Jerome stepped between Kenny and Rock Hard, Charlene's smoky warmth mixing with the hot, oily scent of machinery. "Back up," Jerome told the house, and it sounded more like a plea than a command.

Rock Hard didn't care about pleas. It cared about the next donation window, about isolating the one person who might actually prove something.

Kenny stared at the tiny red light on his recorder, willing it to capture the moment the hum changed. He got what he'd wanted - he'd gotten evidence of selective routing, at least a fragment of it, enough to confirm his suspicion.

But the price landed immediately, heavy and physical.

Rock Hard's body angled, narrowing the corridor until Kenny's world became tile, heat, and the sound of his own breathing. Behind him, Jenna's TTS system buzzed again, louder than before, like the control room had noticed he'd started counting back.

Kenny swallowed hard. He didn't stop recording.

He just realized, with a sick clarity, that the house didn't need to hide the microphones.

It only needed to isolate the person who could map them.

CHAPTER 5

Jenna Flags Vince's Deleted Videos

Kenny was still gone down the corridor, the door sealed with that smug little click the house always made when it wanted everyone to understand consequences were real. From the living room media area, the silence felt staged - like the house had turned down the volume on the contestants and turned it up on the cameras. The wall screens glowed with paused thumbnails, and the air smelled faintly of warm plastic and the lemon cleaner the place used when someone was about to get embarrassed.

Vince Caldwell sat on the edge of the couch that had already been flipped once today by a viewer's donation, his spine stiff as if posture could block data. He kept glancing toward the control room window, where Jenna's silhouette moved behind glass - head tilted, hands busy, her attention locked on something that wasn't happening in the room but was definitely happening to him. He'd built his whole "confidence" persona on control: the smile that didn't sweat, the laugh that made people assume he'd already won. Now the house was proving that control could be yanked away with a few taps and a donation amount.

His phone - officially "house-issued," unofficially a leash - buzzed with nothing. No new message. No pep talk. Just the blank certainty of waiting. Vince's YouTube history wasn't a rumor. It wasn't a rumor for anyone who'd ever scrolled. It was there, cataloged, clipped, and searchable. And the thing about being searchable was that the internet never forgot. Jenna didn't have to "find" anything. She just had to pull the right files at the right moment, run them through the show's state of the art TTS donation system, and watch the house do what it did best: turn private mess into public entertainment.

Phil McCracken's voice rolled through the speakers, loud enough to make the windows vibrate. "Ladies and gentlemen, degenerates and insomniacs," he drawled, as if calling them that was a kindness. "We've got a donation cycle coming up, and the house is... curious."

Vince stood too fast. The room's temperature seemed to drop with his movement, or maybe it was just the HVAC kicking into a colder setting the moment his nervous system spiked. The couch cushions pressed back against him with a memory of being thrown like a prop. He'd hated that flip - hated the humiliation of losing his footing in front of Bree, hated that Darla looked like she'd been waiting all day for someone to slip. But the humiliation wasn't the real problem.

The real problem was that humiliation could be edited. It could be paired with his past. It could be set to voiceovers. It could be weaponized into a "reaction challenge," the kind of thing viewers loved because it looked like justice while it was really just entertainment with receipts.

Vince swallowed. His throat felt dry, like he'd been breathing dust off the carpet for hours.

Jenna's voice came through a speaker channel only the control room seemed to use - crisp, clipped, almost bored. "Cameras are live," she said, the words landing like a countdown even though no timer appeared on any screen. "Donation window - active."

Vince's jaw tightened. He couldn't out-talk a system. He couldn't sweeten a panel, charm a circuit, or threaten a server into behaving. All he could do was try to stop whatever Jenna was about to surface - delete nothing, because the show wasn't built for him to win that way. The house ran on what the internet paid to reveal. And Jenna, sitting behind the glass, had the kind of access that made "deleted" feel like a joke.

"Vince," Phil said, closer now, as if he'd slid his voice through the room's air to find him. "You've been real quiet for someone who keeps saying he's here to dominate."

Vince put a smile on like armor. "I'm just conserving energy," he replied, and his voice came out steadier than his fingers, which wouldn't stop flexing. "Dominance is a long

game.”

“Sure,” Phil said, sing-song, like he’d heard that line from a hundred people who didn’t know the show had teeth. “Well, the teeth are getting closer.”

A buzz rolled through the room - subtle at first, like a phone vibrating under a pillow. The wall screen closest to Vince flickered, then sharpened, showing a donation feed that didn’t display the amount, just the message text and the tag that told the house what it was supposed to do with it. Jenna’s hands moved behind the glass, fast and precise, the way a bartender works when the line is long and someone’s going to complain about ice.

Vince leaned toward the screen, eyes narrowing as if he could read Jenna’s intentions off her posture.

The message loaded. Not public enough to be shouted, not private enough to be safe.

His stomach turned, because the message wasn’t asking for something new. It was asking for something old - something “deleted,” something scraped from the edges of the internet and dragged back into the light. Jenna’s control room access meant deleted content could still be surfaced, and Vince hated the way that truth made his confidence persona feel like a costume from a thrift store: expensive-looking until you got close enough to see the seams.

He heard the faint sound of Kenny’s absence echoing down the hall - like a door that had closed too hard. Kenny had tested the microphones and paid for it with isolation. Vince had watched from afar, watching the house punish curiosity. He’d told himself he’d be safer by staying polished, by staying quiet. But staying polished didn’t stop a donation from finding his weak spot.

Phil’s tone sharpened. “Oh, that’s gonna hit.”

Jenna’s silhouette paused behind the glass. Her head tilted, and Vince saw the smallest change in her body language - like she’d just confirmed something. The screen flashed again, and this time the house didn’t just display text. It triggered.

The living room lights dimmed, then brightened with a white glare that made Vince's skin feel too exposed. A lower speaker crackled. "Please remain seated," the house said in that dead-neutral voice it used when it wanted obedience to feel voluntary.

Vince didn't sit.

He stepped forward, toward the media area's edge, toward the place where the house fed information to the room. "Jenna!" he called, and the name sounded too human in a space run by machines and money. "Don't - "

Her response came not through the room speakers but through the same channel that carried her earlier "Cameras are live" line. "Deleted" isn't a promise," she said, and the casualness in her tone made Vince's blood go colder. "It's a negotiation with the past."

Before he could argue, the wall screen swung from donation text to a video thumbnail.

His face stared back at him - years younger, smug in a way he'd since grown out of, laughing like he wasn't going to pay for it. The clip was short, but the sound carried through the room clearly: his own voice, recorded and preserved and now being aired at full volume. He heard the words he'd tried to bury, the jokes he'd made when the internet still treated him like a novelty instead of a problem.

Vince lunged for the remote panel mounted low on the media console. His hand slapped it, fingers scrambling over buttons with no logic he could understand. The panel didn't respond to his touch like a normal device. It responded like a thing that had already decided.

Phil's voice boomed, delighted. "Reaction challenge!" he shouted, and the word "challenge" snapped like a whip. "Vince is up!"

The house played the clip again, louder this time, as if volume could force acceptance. Vince's chest tightened with the heat of embarrassment. Darla would eat this alive. Bree would look at him like she'd just heard a new way to be hurt. Jerome

would probably stare, Charlene's smoky warmth nowhere near enough to soften anything.

The worst part was that Vince couldn't even pretend it was a misunderstanding. It was him. It was his voice. It was his "confidence" persona - now exposed as a performance built on content he'd deleted because it didn't age well.

The room filled with the noise of laughter from somewhere - maybe the control room speakers, maybe a contestant reacting, maybe the house itself enjoying the moment. Vince's ears rang. He could smell the lemon cleaner again, sharp and sterile, as if the show wanted to wipe away the mess after it made it.

He forced himself to watch - forced his eyes to stay open when his instinct was to look away. Jenna's work had turned his past into a live feed, and the show didn't care that he'd tried to remove it. The house cared about reactions.

Vince swallowed hard, then turned his head toward the others. Darla stood not far off, eyes bright, mouth curved like she was tasting something sweet. "So that's what you were doing with all that 'confidence,'" she said, voice smooth with cruelty. "Deleted for a reason."

Vince's throat worked. "That was a long time ago," he managed.

Darla leaned closer, as if proximity made her point sharper. "Long time ago," she echoed, and the air around her seemed colder. "Or just long enough for people to forget until now?"

Across the room, Bree hovered near Mr. Whiskers, her stuffed animal pressed to her chest like a shield. Bree's eyes flicked to Vince's screen, then away, then back again - like she was trying to decide whether sympathy was allowed. Mr. Whiskers didn't move, but Bree's grip tightened, knuckles pale.

Phil McCracken paced in front of the camera line, grinning like a man who'd gotten a donation request approved. "Tell us what you're thinking, Vince," he said. "Tell the house."

Vince felt trapped in the space between his own past and the audience's appetite. He could feel the donation system humming in the walls, the mechanism behind Jenna's control room pulls. He couldn't out-talk a system, but he could still decide how he reacted.

So he did the only thing that felt like power.

He took a breath, let the embarrassment burn without letting it own him, and looked directly at the screen - directly at the version of himself that was now being played like entertainment. Then he stood straighter and spoke, voice controlled in a way that was almost convincing.

"That's me," he said, and the words tasted like metal. "And I'm not proud of it."

The honesty landed like a punch. Darla blinked, caught off-guard for half a second, like her script had been torn. Phil's grin faltered, then reformed into something sharper - because even vulnerability could be turned into a reaction for the cameras.

"Not proud," Phil repeated, delighted and suspicious at the same time. "That's new."

Vince kept his eyes on the screen, because looking away would make it feel like he'd lost. "I deleted it because it wasn't the person I wanted to be," he said. "And apparently, the internet disagrees."

Jenna's silhouette moved again behind the glass. Vince saw her hand hover over a control, fast and deliberate. Like she'd heard his words and decided they weren't enough.

The house buzzed. The lighting shifted, warmer now, like the machine was pleased with itself.

A second message slid onto the donation feed screen - different tag, different intent. This one didn't ask for "deleted content." It asked for a bigger, more humiliating kind of proof. Vince felt it before he read it, like his body recognized danger in the same way a tongue recognizes poison.

Phil's voice went bright. "Oh, that's brutal."

Vince's stomach dropped. The house was already lining up the next wave of humiliation, already remaking the moment into something viewers could twist.

The wall screen changed again - another clip, another angle, another piece of his past. This one wasn't just him talking. It was him interacting, caught mid-reaction to something he'd said he'd never do again.

Vince's hands clenched at his sides. He'd prevented one planned reveal - not by bargaining, not by deleting, but by forcing the moment to become about accountability instead of shock. But Jenna's behind-the-scenes control had turned his "confidence" persona into a liability anyway, and now the cost was immediate.

Darla's smile returned, bigger this time. Bree's grip on Mr. Whiskers tightened until the seams looked like they might strain. Jerome wasn't in Vince's line of sight, but Vince could feel Charlene's absence like a pressure in the room - like the house was stealing warmth too.

Jenna's voice crackled again, calm as a judge. "Donation fulfilled."

The screen played.

Vince watched his own past laugh back at him, louder than any apology, and realized the show didn't want to bury his history. It wanted to use it - again and again - until he performed the version of himself the audience could chew.

And somewhere down the corridor, Kenny's silence hummed like a warning that the house never ran out of ways to turn curiosity into payment.

CHAPTER 6

Marcus Breaks When the Grill Is Targeted

The backyard station had been built to look cozy in daylight - string lights, a little checkerboard tile, a grill with a nameplate that said CHARLENE like this was a friendly cookout and not a live-fire negotiation between strangers. Right then, though, the afternoon got swallowed by a low ceiling of smoke as Charlene's grates hissed and Jerome fanned the heat into a steady roar. The metal was already blackened from use, the kind of soot that never fully washed off, no matter how many times you scrubbed like you could outwork guilt.

Marcus stood just inside the fence line, watching the others orbit the grill like it was a campfire they could warm their hands over. Not him. Not today. Today was supposed to be him keeping his status intact - his voice, his posture, his agreements holding weight. Darla had been busy claiming corners and dragging people into her bed-rotation arguments, and Kenny's silence down the corridor had been loud enough to make Marcus feel watched even when nobody looked his way. And now Vince was publicly reacting to his own clips, letting the house chew on him while Marcus tried to act like he wasn't counting every donation window as a threat.

Phil's voice floated from somewhere inside the house, tinny through walls and vents. "Contestants, keep your stations ready. We've got a challenge setup coming, and the internet never wastes a good moment."

Marcus gripped the edge of the prep table until his knuckles stung. He could feel the heat on his forearms. He could also feel the tension in his chest, the familiar pressure that came when he didn't know who was being targeted next. He'd survived this far by staying dominant - by being the guy who could turn a room into a resource instead of a trap. He didn't need sympathy. He needed control.

He leaned closer to Charlene's side burner, pretending to check temps, pretending his attention wasn't locked on the way Jerome kept glancing at the control screen mounted near the patio door. Jerome's eyes flickered toward the house every time the lights blinked. The last time the house reacted on Jenna's timer, Bree's whole body had gone stiff like she'd just realized she could be moved like furniture.

Marcus didn't plan on being furniture.

"Marcus," Jerome said, voice pitched low over the grill's steady crackle. "You good?"

Marcus gave him a smile that looked smooth in his head and sharper in the world. "I'm good. I'm always good."

Jerome didn't buy it, but he nodded anyway, like he'd learned which lies were worth tolerating. Charlene's fat dripped onto the flame in ugly ribbons - loud, bright, too alive - and Marcus could feel his anger trying to find an excuse to become action.

Then the punishment started without asking anyone's permission.

The air changed first. Not smoke - something colder slid through the heat like someone had opened a freezer door inside the walls. The string lights above the station flickered once, then steadied, and the grill's roar cut out mid-sizzle like a microphone being yanked.

Charlene sat there, suddenly silent, her grates dull under a thin layer of ash. Jerome's hand froze above the tongs.

"What the hell - " Jerome began.

A buzzing sound crawled into the yard, a mechanical whine that set Marcus's teeth on edge. From the patio speaker, Phil's voice sharpened. "Donation just came through. Viewer choice. Keep calm."

Marcus didn't keep calm. Marcus watched the corner of the grill station where Charlene's control panel sat - buttons, a small dial, a screen that usually stayed dark unless the house was pushing a new setting. Now the screen lit up with a single red

indicator and a word Marcus didn't recognize at first because the house didn't use words often. It used consequences.

Jerome swallowed. "Charlene...?"

The grill's side vents snapped open with a metallic clack, and a blast of heat shoved itself outward. Not cooking heat - target heat. It slammed into the space right in front of Charlene like the house had picked a spot on purpose. Marcus jerked back as the air turned brutal and dry, burning the back of his throat. The smell hit a second later: hot grease gone wrong, sharp and choking, like something you'd try to scrub off your skin but couldn't.

Bree's voice drifted from somewhere behind the fence, muffled by distance and panic. Marcus caught only fragments over the buzzing: "That's not - " and then a sharp inhale when she realized it wasn't just equipment.

Jerome moved automatically, stepping in with protective hands toward the grill, like he could shield Charlene with his body. "Stop. Stop - "

Phil cut in, too cheerful for the way everyone's skin tightened. "Jerome, you've been selected. Charlene's about to be... adjusted. Keep your hands steady."

Marcus stared at the grill, at the way the heat kept pulsing in measured bursts, like a countdown. His mind wanted to label it as random - viewer chaos, a mechanical hiccup, a mistake. But nothing about it felt accidental. The heat was too precise. The silence before the blast was too timed.

And the internet had a history of paying for exactly what it wanted.

Marcus felt his status wobble in real time. If this was a targeted punishment, if Charlene was the focus, then Jerome would become the story. Jerome's grief - Jerome's dad, Charlene as the tether - would be turned into a spectacle, and Marcus knew how quickly the house could turn sympathy into leverage.

He couldn't let that happen. Not because he cared about Jerome's feelings. Because if the narrative shifted, his leverage shifted with it, and he didn't have time to rebuild.

He stepped forward before anyone could stop him. "Jenna - " he called out, like the control room could hear him through the walls. "Phil. Tell them to cut it. It's too far."

Jerome turned his head toward Marcus, eyes wide and wet with heat. "Marcus, don't - "

Marcus didn't slow. He planted himself beside the grill station, ignoring the burn that licked his sleeves. "If the house wants a reaction, they're getting one. But not this - "

A new buzz hit, lower this time, and the grill's panel flashed again. The heat surge didn't stop. Instead, it shifted - like the house had moved the target. Now the blast pushed toward the side rack where Jerome kept charcoal and spices.

The smell changed immediately: scorched pepper, acrid smoke, something sweet burned down to bitter. Marcus coughed, eyes watering. He tasted grease on the back of his tongue.

Jerome's hand shot out for the rack, and Marcus grabbed his wrist at the last second, yanking him back hard enough to make Jerome stumble. "Don't touch it!"

Jerome stared at Marcus like Marcus had slapped him. The anger in Marcus's chest surged with relief - because anger, at least, made sense. Anger was something he could control.

Marcus saw Jenna's control signals in his head, the way he imagined the donation system routing messages. He didn't know the mechanics - he'd never had Kenny's obsession with mapping microphones - but the result was clear. Someone out there had paid to make Charlene the center of pain, and Marcus was about to look like the guy who couldn't stop it.

That was unacceptable.

"Who did this?" Marcus demanded, voice too loud. "Is it Darla? Is it - "

"Marcus," Jerome said, quiet now, like he was trying to keep the fire from hearing him. "Don't. Please."

Marcus met Jerome's eyes, and something in Jerome's face - fear mixed with shame - made Marcus's stomach twist. This wasn't just a punishment. It was a violation of the thing Jerome kept alive.

Marcus wanted to explode at the person pulling strings. He wanted to point at the house and scream that it was cruel. He wanted to do all the righteous things that would make him look big, brave, necessary.

But the house didn't reward righteousness. It rewarded reactions.

Phil's voice came again, smooth as a blade. "Marcus Bennett. Viewer message detected. Keep your hands where we can see them."

Marcus froze. "What?"

The backyard lights dimmed for a half-second. Then brightened. The panel on Charlene's side screen flashed, and a line of text scrolled fast enough to be read only if you were already looking for trouble.

Marcus read it anyway. His stomach dropped.

A viewer message - short, vicious - was now tied to him. Not Jerome. Not Bree. Him. The house had decided Marcus was part of the punishment.

Jerome's breath came in short bursts. "Marcus, it's not - "

"It is," Marcus snapped. "It's all of it. They're using you and they're using me."

Marcus turned toward the patio door as if he could see into the control room through wood and drywall. The heat behind him pulsed again and the station smelled like burnt fat and cheap metal.

"What did you do?" Darla's voice cut in from the perimeter, sharp and delighted like she'd been waiting for the moment to prove she was right about everyone. Darla stepped into the edge of the station, chewing on her own confidence. Her eyes were bright, and for once her smile didn't look like a threat to someone else. It looked like she thought the house had finally chosen her angle.

Marcus pointed at the grill without thinking. "This is targeted. It's your people - "

Darla blinked. "My people?"

Jerome flinched like he'd been hit by the accusation. Bree's footsteps scraped closer on the gravel. Mr. Whiskers's small, familiar presence - quiet, stubborn - was somewhere behind Bree, pressed close against her as if the stuffed animal could absorb smoke and keep comfort intact.

Marcus's head spun with the need to win the argument. He didn't care if he was wrong. He cared that he was seen as the guy who could take the hit and still throw it back.

Bree's voice came strained. "Marcus, don't - "

Marcus spun toward her, and his temper found a new target because it always did. "Don't what? Don't call out the fact that the house is picking someone to hurt and calling it a challenge?"

Bree's shoulders stiffened. She looked at Charlene, then at Jerome, then at Marcus, like she was trying to decide whether his anger was protection or sabotage.

"Marcus," Bree said, softer, "you're making it worse."

The house buzzed again, louder. The grill's panel flashed red, and the heat surge turned into a series of quick bursts that made the station feel like it was stuttering. The sound of metal vibrating joined the crackle of the flame. Jerome backed up, hands hovering uselessly.

Phil's voice rolled over it all, cheerful and cruel. "Donation escalation. Marcus, step away from Charlene."

Marcus didn't step away. He took one more step forward, closer to the grill, closer to the pain. "No. You don't get to - "

The heat burst hit his forearm hard enough to make him jerk back and hiss through clenched teeth. The sting was immediate, bright, humiliating. Marcus's anger surged again, and he let it show on his face - because part of him believed pain could buy respect if he refused to look scared.

Jerome stared at him, jaw tight. Darla laughed once, short and mean. "Look at him," she said, and the words landed like she'd just bought the moment. "Marcus can't even handle a grill."

Bree's eyes flicked to Darla, then back to Marcus, and Marcus felt his social leverage peel away in real time like tape coming off a wall. His anger had been supposed to keep him dominant. Instead, it made him a liability - something the house could exploit and everyone else could discuss.

Phil's voice came again, sharper now, no longer playing nice. "Marcus Bennett, you've been flagged for heightened restrictions during the upcoming challenge setup. Move to the designated waiting area."

A mechanical click came from the patio fence. The gravel under Marcus's shoes felt suddenly less like ground and more like a boundary being drawn. He didn't see the waiting area yet, but he felt it - the house rearranging space to match the story it wanted.

Marcus turned his head, searching for something he could control. Jenna's control room might as well have been a god. The internet might as well have been a second host.

He looked at Jerome, hoping for solidarity.

Jerome looked back, and his expression wasn't angry. It was disappointed. Like Marcus had betrayed the moment when Marcus could've been useful.

Marcus opened his mouth to speak - some sharp retort, some excuse, some dominance-saving line - and the heat buzzed again, cutting him off. The grill's bursts slowed, then stopped, but the smell stayed. Burnt grease clung to the air like an accusation.

The social circle tightened around the grill as if the station was now a stage and everyone needed a better seat.

Darla leaned toward Bree, voice sweet as poison. "See? He can't handle pressure. He's all talk."

Bree didn't answer her. She was watching Marcus like she was trying to decide whether to fear him or pity him.

Jerome stepped closer to Charlene, touching the grill's side panel with a care that made Marcus's anger feel even more pathetic by comparison. He murmured something Marcus couldn't hear over the cooling metal. Grief wrapped around the gesture like smoke.

Marcus stood there, forearm throbbing, throat raw with heat, and realized the setback wasn't just the restriction. It was the way the house had turned his aggression into proof that he couldn't be trusted with the house's momentum.

During the first real challenge setup, when everyone needed to move together, Marcus had just made himself the problem.

Phil's voice floated from the speakers again, softer now, almost intimate. "Contestants, prepare. The house has already started the next phase."

Marcus stared at the patio door where the waiting area would be - somewhere he'd be separated, somewhere his voice wouldn't carry. He could feel the house humming

with a new plan, and he couldn't stop thinking about how fast the others had decided what his anger meant.

He'd wanted control.

Instead, he'd given them a reason to take it.

CHAPTER 7

Tiffany's Sponsorship Becomes a Trap

Charlene's lid was still warm when Tiffany shoved a sponsor tote into the kitchen prep area like it had elbows. The air smelled like propane and citrus cleaner, the kind they use to make everything look "fresh" on camera. Somewhere deeper in the house, someone laughed too loud - then cut off fast, like the sound had tripped a wire.

The kitchen counters were already staged with Rock Hard bottles and branded wipes. The labels shone under the harsh overheads, too crisp to be real. Marcus had been restricted after the grill incident - Tiffany could feel the change in the way people moved around the space, tighter, like the rules had teeth now. And the house was primed for new alliances, because it always was. It didn't just want chaos. It wanted chaos that produced content.

Tiffany's phone - no, not hers. The show's tablet with the sponsor dashboard - buzzed in her palm. Her sponsorship tie-in sat there like a dare, a clean logo floating over a messy house. She'd spent the last hours smoothing her face into "approachable," letting Bree's nerves drift past her, letting Darla's attitude bounce off her like cheap plastic. If she could steer the next challenge outcome, keep her brand intact, she could buy herself something more valuable than comfort: distance from the punishment wheel.

"Rock Hard?" Jerome's voice came from the doorway, gruff and careful. Charlene hissed faintly on the other side of the partition, like she was still offended. "You're really pushing that right now?"

Tiffany didn't look at him at first. She pulled the sponsor wipes across the counter in deliberate swipes, the kind that looked satisfying on screen. "It's a sponsor. It's literally the whole point."

Jerome's gaze tracked the bottles, then flicked to the camera mounted in the corner. His shoulders were tense in a way that didn't match the casual words. Charlene - his grill - sat nearby like a loyal pet, scorched edges glinting as if she'd survived worse than heat.

Behind Tiffany, the TTS system chimed - soft at first, like a polite knock. Then the kitchen lights flickered once, twice, and the sound came again, louder, impatient.

Jenna's voice floated through the speaker in the control-room cadence, bright and merciless. "Contestants. Donation window active."

Tiffany's stomach tightened. Donations meant messages, and messages meant the house could "interpret" a sponsor tie-in like it was a legal document. Her brand wasn't just a sticker; it was leverage. And leverage was fragile.

Darla appeared like a storm that had learned where the cameras were. She didn't walk into the kitchen so much as claim it with her eyes. Her hair was pinned neat, her mouth not. She looked younger than her anger, which made it worse.

"You're cleaning," Darla said, voice syrupy with suspicion. "Or you're hiding something."

Tiffany finally turned, letting the bottles catch the overhead glare. "Hiding what? A sponsor? A wipe? A strategy?"

Darla's smile sharpened. "A strategy that benefits Tiffany, and nobody else."

The words landed like a slap because Darla had the kind of confidence that made people forget to argue. Bree was somewhere down the hall, quiet and tight around her shoulders - Mr. Whiskers tucked close, comfort weaponized into silence. Darla knew that too. Tiffany could feel it, like a pressure change before a storm.

Phil McCracken's voice came through the house speakers, smooth as a knife sliding out of its sheath. "Viewers at home have paid to influence your next move."

Tiffany's fingers hovered over the Rock Hard bottles. She could almost hear the audience reading her like a menu. She wanted to keep her image clean - no mess, no accusations, no sponsor backlash that would make Jenna's eyebrow go from amused to murderous.

Then the tablet buzzed again, and the sponsor tie-in panel flashed with a donation route indicator Tiffany hadn't seen before. It wasn't just "show content." It was her specific connection - her name and her brand - being routed into the house like a live wire.

A text-to-speech request scrolled across the screen, the words appearing like a verdict.

"PROOF OR PAY."

The phrase made Tiffany's throat go dry. That wasn't a generic demand. That was a trap dressed as a game.

She looked up at the kitchen cameras. "No," she said, and hated how small it sounded.

Jenna's voice over the speakers was cheerful, like she was describing dessert. "Tiffany Nguyen. The sponsor tie-in must be validated during challenge prep. Viewers require proof."

Jerome frowned, turning toward her. "Proof of what?"

Tiffany swallowed. The tablet flickered, then pushed a new message prompt - another donation route, another buzz. The house was already doing math on her reputation. If she complied wrong, she'd look like a sellout. If she refused, she'd look like a liar. Either way, she'd be the one holding the bag for whatever the audience wanted to see.

Darla stepped closer, lowering her voice so it still carried. "You bought your way into safety, Tiffany. Now you're going to buy your way out."

Tiffany's jaw tightened. "Don't talk like you know what I bought."

Darla's eyes gleamed. "I know this house. It doesn't care about your sponsor. It cares about who breaks first."

The door slammed somewhere farther down the corridor. Footsteps echoed - fast, then uneven. Someone was being punished or rerouted, and the sound had that familiar "house mechanism" rhythm, the clack of something locking into place.

Tiffany could practically feel the earlier turmoil still vibrating through the walls. Marcus had been restricted after the grill incident; the house had already punished someone for making a scene. Now it wanted a new scene - and it wanted her to be the center of it.

Her tablet chimed again, louder this time. A new donation request appeared, routed through her sponsor tie-in.

"Rock Hard will be challenged. Tiffany must choose an ally to sacrifice to secure brand integrity."

Tiffany stared at the words until they blurred. The house didn't just want content. It wanted a betrayal with clean, sponsor-friendly lighting.

She could already see how it would look. Viewers would clip it, loop it, sell it back as entertainment. Jenna would smile on camera while she watched Tiffany's credibility burn in real time. If Tiffany picked the wrong person, she'd lose the alliance she was building. If she picked the right one, she'd still be branded as the kind of person who could do it.

Jerome shifted, sensing the temperature in the room changed. "Tiffany. What's happening?"

Tiffany forced her voice steady. "They want proof. They want me to - " She stopped herself from saying it out loud. Saying it made it more real, and she refused to give the house even that courtesy.

Darla's grin widened. "Come on. Say it. Who are you going to toss aside for your brand?"

Tiffany's eyes flicked to the corridor where Bree's quiet presence lived. Bree had been trying to keep things low-drama, trying to survive without turning into a villain. Mr. Whiskers - her stuffed animal companion - had already become part of her comfort strategy, something the house could poke at if it wanted. And Darla loved poking.

If Tiffany didn't make a choice now, the house would make it for her. That's how these systems worked. They didn't ask. They cornered you and called it "engagement."

Tiffany turned back to the tablet. Her sponsor tie-in panel was pulsing, waiting for her decision. The kitchen felt too bright, too clean around the edges, like someone had scrubbed the blood out of the scene before it happened.

She heard Bree's soft voice from the hallway, like she'd been trying to be polite to the air. "I can help."

Tiffany's stomach twisted. Bree stepping in would make her look sympathetic - and it would make Bree the easy target. Darla would push harder, and the house would eat it up.

Tiffany made her choice before she could talk herself out of it.

She reached for the Rock Hard bottles and slammed them back onto the counter with a sharp clack - just loud enough to steal the room's attention. Then she jabbed a finger toward Bree's direction.

"Bree," Tiffany called, voice carrying. "You're the one who's validating the sponsor tie-in. You'll do the proof."

Jerome's head snapped toward her. "What? Tiffany - "

Bree appeared at the doorway, eyes wide, Mr. Whiskers clutched like a lifeline. The stuffed animal's fabric was warm from Bree's hands, and it looked ridiculous in the glare of the kitchen lights - like innocence trying to negotiate with a machine.

Bree blinked. "Me?"

Tiffany kept her face neutral. No panic. No apology. Just decision. "You talk to stuffed animals, right? So you're good at... convincing people."

It was cruel, but it was pointed, and it was fast. Tiffany could feel the audience's attention slam into the room through the donation route like a crowd pushing forward at a concert.

Darla let out a delighted little laugh. "Oh, that's good. Tiffany's choosing her brand over her alliance."

Jerome's expression tightened into something hurt. "Bree didn't do anything."

Tiffany met Jerome's eyes for one second and hated the guilt that tried to bloom. She couldn't afford guilt. She needed immediate safety. She needed the sponsor to stay clean. She needed to not be the next person locked in a corridor with nowhere to pivot.

"Not anything," Tiffany said softly, then louder, "just the easiest target."

Bree's mouth parted, and for a heartbeat Tiffany expected Mr. Whiskers to somehow talk sense into the situation. But the house didn't run on comfort. It ran on punishment and leverage.

TTS chimed again. Jenna's voice warmed, satisfied. "Proof accepted. Rock Hard validation secured."

The kitchen lights steadied. The buzzing in the walls stopped. The air felt a fraction cooler, like the house had backed off - just enough to keep Tiffany inside its rules.

Jerome exhaled hard, like he'd been holding his breath since the couch flip earlier, like he still remembered how quickly the house could turn a small moment into a disaster. "Tiffany, why would you - "

Tiffany cut him off. "Because if I don't choose, the house chooses for me. And it picks the person least able to fight back."

Darla stepped closer to Bree, her voice sweet as poison. "Go on, Bree. Prove you're useful."

Bree looked at Tiffany like she was trying to decide whether Tiffany was cruel or trapped. Her grip tightened on Mr. Whiskers until the fabric wrinkled. "You just - "

Tiffany didn't let herself flinch. She made herself hold the line. "I did what I had to."

From the speakers, Phil McCracken's laugh rolled out, smooth and delighted. "Ohhh. That's the kind of betrayal that keeps the sponsor contracts alive!"

Tiffany's skin crawled, but she didn't look away. The house wanted her to show fear. She refused. If she was going to be a villain, she'd at least be a villain with control.

Then her tablet buzzed again, and this time the message wasn't about Bree.

"BRAND INTEGRITY MAINTAINED. NEXT: AUDIENCE SELECTS TIERED TARGETING."

Tiffany felt her stomach drop. The safety wasn't a gift. It was a pause. The proof or pay ultimatum had worked, but it had also stamped her as the pivot point - the next person viewers would want to pull apart to see what she'd do.

Darla watched her with a smile that promised escalation, like she'd just been handed a new knife. Jerome stood between Tiffany and Bree for a moment, protective and angry in the same breath.

Bree's eyes were wet, but she didn't cry. She just looked at Tiffany like she'd finally understood the cost of Tiffany's sponsorship tie-in.

“Mr. Whiskers,” Bree whispered, voice shaking just enough to be heard over the buzz of the house.

Tiffany heard it too - the stuffed animal’s name, the comfort strategy turned to prayer. It hit her harder than any donation request. She’d thrown an ally under the bus for immediate safety, and it had worked.

But the bus had left tracks.

Darla’s next question came quick, sharp, and targeted at Tiffany’s throat. “So who’s it going to be when the house asks again?”

Tiffany opened her mouth to answer, then stopped. Because she didn’t know the answer yet. And the house loved that uncertainty.

In the kitchen prep area, under sponsor logos and flickering control lights that now behaved, Tiffany Nguyen held the Rock Hard bottles like trophies and watched Bree clutch Mr. Whiskers like a warning.

Her brand was intact.

For now.

And somewhere in Jenna’s control room, another donation route was already being priced.

CHAPTER 8

Bree Outsmarts the Donation Loop

The living room felt smaller the moment the hallway lights blinked - like the house itself was trying to decide whether it wanted them to breathe or panic. Bree stood near the coffee table, careful with her feet, careful with her face, listening to the soft, stupid comfort of Mr. Whiskers' stitched whiskers against her palm. The stuffing warmed under her thumb from where she'd been holding him too long.

Darla's voice still had that sharp, victorious edge from earlier, when Tiffany had thrown somebody under the bus just to buy herself five minutes of safety. Now the room was full of people pretending they didn't hear the betrayal in every laugh. Marcus paced like he was wearing out the floorboards by being angry at them. Jerome kept glancing at Charlene - his grill - like he could bully grief into behaving. And Kenny... Kenny didn't talk. Kenny watched. Quiet, too still, as if he'd learned the hard way that movement got noticed by the wrong kind of attention.

Phil McCracken's voice floated out of the ceiling speakers, bright and cheerful in the way a knife can be bright.

"Eight strangers," Phil said, like the phrase wasn't rotting in their mouths. "Several weeks. Challenges. Alliances. Betrayals for protein bars."

Bree flinched at the word protein, because the sound system liked to use whatever hunger was closest to the surface. Around her, the air was warm from bodies and electronics, and it smelled faintly like scorched dust from the last time the house punished someone for being curious.

Then Jenna's voice cut in - clean, professional, and somehow colder than the rest of them.

"Cameras are live in thirty seconds."

Bree didn't look up at the ceiling. She didn't need to. Everyone felt the timing like a pulse. Thirty seconds meant the TTS donation window was about to spit out a message, and that message would crawl into their behavior like a parasite. The house had already flipped the couch. It had already locked Darla in the corridor after Kenny's testing. It had already made Marcus pay for his temper. It had already turned Vince's past into a public spectacle.

Bree swallowed and pressed Mr. Whiskers closer to her chest.

This time, she wanted control of something that wasn't hers by default.

Not control of the system. Not control of the viewers. She'd learned those were fantasies that got people hurt.

She wanted control of the next reaction - of the chain reaction that always followed the donation announcement. If she could predict which kind of message was coming through, she could steer the room before the house could twist their instincts into a trap.

"Bree," Darla said, sweet as poison, stepping closer with her chin tilted. Her voice carried that Dallas confidence that didn't ask permission from reality. "Don't stand there clutching the stuffed animal like it's a shield. Shields crack."

Bree glanced at Darla's hands. No shake. No sweat. Darla was ready for a fight she could win. Bree felt Mr. Whiskers' fabric scrape her skin when she tightened her grip.

"It's not a shield," Bree said. "It's... comfort."

Darla's smile widened. "Comfort is what you call it when you don't know what's coming for you."

From the corner of her vision, Kenny moved - just a shift of weight, like he was adjusting something in his head and not his body. He looked toward the ceiling speakers, then toward the wall panels near the living room console, where the house's routing seemed to live.

Bree's mind snagged on what Kenny had done before - his silence, his focus, the way he'd tested the microphone system like it was a puzzle instead of a weapon. If Jenna could route messages, if the house could selectively respond...

Then maybe the loop wasn't random. Maybe it was patterned. Maybe it was predictable in the way a predator is predictable: not because it's kind, but because it's consistent.

Bree turned her head slightly, just enough to look at Mr. Whiskers without looking at him. The little stitched animal didn't speak - he never did, not in words - but Bree had gotten good at reading him like she read frightened pets. The tension in the room pulled at his "mood" the way panic pulled at breathing. Tonight, Mr. Whiskers felt... braced. Like the next donation would be sharp, immediate, designed to make someone snap.

Jerome cleared his throat. It sounded too loud in the room. "If it's another punishment, can we - " He stopped, jaw tightening around whatever he wanted to say. His grief sat close to his eyes, like the house had installed it there. Charlene's presence - metal and heat and memory - made him brave in short bursts.

"Don't," Darla said, cutting him off. "We don't get to 'can we' anything. We get what the house gives."

Marcus's laugh came out harsh. "She's right. The house gives. The viewers buy."

"Viewers don't buy feelings," Bree murmured before she could stop herself.

The words hung there, stupid and earnest. Darla's gaze snapped to her like Bree had slapped her.

Kenny finally spoke, low and flat. "They buy outcomes."

Bree's throat tightened. Kenny's voice wasn't angry. It was... careful. Like he'd practiced being quiet so the wrong ears wouldn't find him.

That was her obstacle. Not just Darla's attitude. Not just the house's chaos. Her own impulse to believe she could soothe people through it. Comfort wasn't enough when the system could turn comfort into leverage.

Mr. Whiskers' stuffing warmed against her palm, and Bree hated how her heart still wanted to be gentle. Hated that her gentleness made her an easy target.

Phil's voice came through again, and the cheerful host tone was almost insulting.

"Ladies and gentlemen, degenerates and insomniacs - "

Jenna interrupted, sharper, like she couldn't stand waiting for Phil to finish his act.

"Donation announcement in ten seconds."

Bree's eyes darted across faces - Darla's eager aggression, Marcus's clenched fists, Jerome's grief-fueled focus on Charlene, Tiffany's absence of visible comfort after what she'd done earlier. And Jenna's voice in her head, counting down, turning seconds into knives.

Nine. Eight.

Bree's mind sprinted backward through the patterns she'd already survived. Couch flip had targeted the center of the room - forcing movement and exposing who got shoved first. The Vince reaction challenge had turned shame into entertainment. The grill heat blast had made everyone flinch at the same time, and Jerome's Charlene had become a bargaining chip. The sponsor trap had weaponized legitimacy - made someone choose who to sacrifice.

So what would the next message be?

Mr. Whiskers felt like a “door closing” kind of moment. Bree pictured a message that would isolate someone - corridor, bedroom, bathroom - some space where trust couldn’t spread because nobody could reach anyone.

And if the house wanted isolation, Darla would love it. Darla thrived on territory. She’d already staked a claim earlier, acting like the corner room belonged to her by divine decree and not a viewer’s impulse.

Bree looked at Darla.

Darla looked back, eyes bright. “You’re thinking,” she said, like it was a personal insult. “Good. Think about how you’ll lose.”

Five. Four.

Bree didn’t have time to argue. She needed action. She needed to move before the house moved first.

She grabbed Mr. Whiskers and, without asking permission, stepped between Darla and Jerome - between Darla’s hunger for control and Jerome’s fragile grief.

“Jerome,” Bree said quickly, voice low. “Come here.”

Jerome blinked, caught off guard. His hands hovered near Charlene’s imaginary heat, like he wanted to protect something even when he couldn’t. “Why?”

“Because if the donation isolates someone,” Bree said, “they’ll try to do it through territory. They’ll pick the corner. They’ll pick the place you can’t reach without looking like you’re surrendering.”

Darla’s smile vanished. “You don’t get to - ”

Bree cut her off with a glance that felt like a stethoscope pressed to a pulse. “Don’t make it a fight. It’ll become one anyway if you give the house a reason.”

Three. Two.

Kenny's eyes narrowed. He shifted again, and Bree saw it - his attention wasn't just on the ceiling. It was on the routing panel near the living room console, the same place where his earlier testing had seemed to go wrong for Darla.

"One of you is about to get singled out," Kenny said, voice steady but urgent. "And it's not random."

One.

The ceiling speakers crackled, a tiny electrical cough that made everyone's skin lift. Jenna's voice went crisp and bright, the way a game show would sound right before it ruined your life.

"Platinum Package. Five thousand dollars. Rock Hard does whatever you want. Terms and conditions apply."

The room went dead for half a second, like the house had sucked the oxygen out to hear what they'd do next.

Phil's voice - delighted, wicked - rolled in right after.

"Now!" Phil said. "Let's see what the viewers decide."

Bree felt her stomach drop. Platinum meant whatever the viewer paid for wasn't a minor punishment. It wasn't a shove. It wasn't a couch flip. It was a lever. And the worst part was how easy it would be for the lever to be pulled in a direction that broke the group.

Darla's eyes glinted. "Oh," she breathed, like she'd already tasted victory. "They want chaos."

Kenny's hand twitched toward the console, but he didn't touch it. He looked at Bree, and for the first time all day, he looked like he wanted to trust her instead of test her.

Bree didn't have trust to spare. She had timing.

She turned her body slightly so her weight blocked Darla from getting to the corridor entrance. Then she did the thing she hated most: she made it about her.

"Darla," Bree said, loud enough to carry over the crackle of the speakers. "If Rock Hard is being used, it's going to target whoever the house thinks is the easiest to control."

Darla's nostrils flared. "You're trying to - "

"No," Bree said, and felt Mr. Whiskers' fabric bite into her palm as she steadied herself. "I'm trying to redirect it. You want territory? Fine. Take it. Take me instead."

Marcus stared at her. "Bree - "

Jerome's mouth opened, then shut. Charlene's presence in his mind made his shoulders tense like he wanted to step in, to protect, to refuse this kind of sacrifice.

Kenny's voice came out rough. "That's what they'll do. If you stand in the path, the system will choose you to make the point."

Darla's laugh was sharp. "You think you can bargain with the house?"

Bree didn't answer because she couldn't afford honesty. Not the kind that would make Darla feel clever.

The house responded.

The hallway lights shifted from their usual warm tone to a sickly, aggressive white, and the sound system sent a low, humming vibration through the floor. The temperature in the living room dropped by a few degrees, like the house had decided comfort was negotiable.

A door clicked somewhere down the corridor.

Darla's eyes snapped toward it. "See? Corner. They're taking the corner."

Bree's pulse hammered. She'd been right about the pattern - wrong about the direction.

Because the door that clicked wasn't the corner room.

It was the small storage closet near the living room console, the one nobody claimed because it didn't feel like a place a person could own. It felt like a place where the house could put something it didn't want seen.

The closet latch jerked open, and a mechanical arm extended like a bright metal tongue.

A panel slid into view with a thick, sealed bundle and a label that flashed briefly, then dimmed. Bree couldn't read it fast enough to know exactly what it meant, but she felt the message in the air anyway - like a dare aimed at her instincts.

Rock Hard had chosen her.

Bree staggered back, breath coming quick, and Mr. Whiskers slipped from her grasp for a second before she caught him again. She heard Darla's satisfaction like a slap.

"Bree," Darla said, voice sweet again, "you wanted to be the point."

Bree swallowed the panic and forced her hands to work. The bundle was cold and heavy. Plastic crinkled when she touched it, and the smell that rose wasn't blood or smoke - it was something harsher and chemical, like new carpet and disinfectant forced into the same breath.

Kenny moved fast, stepping beside her. "Don't open it."

Bree blinked at him. "How do you know?"

Kenny's jaw tightened. "Because it's Platinum. They don't want you to solve it. They want you to react."

Marcus grabbed the edge of the coffee table like it could anchor him. "Then what do we do?"

Bree stared at the bundle, feeling the house's vibration in her bones. The internal trouble wasn't fear of punishment - it was the part of her that wanted to fix things by touching them, by comforting them, by making it better with gentleness.

But gentleness was how the system got inside.

She looked at Mr. Whiskers. His stitched face didn't judge. He just waited for her to choose.

Bree tightened her grip and did something she'd been avoiding since the beginning: she refused the invitation to be the kind of person the viewers expected.

"I'm not going to react the way they want," she said, voice low enough that only the closest could hear. "I'm going to make it boring."

Darla's eyes widened, annoyed. "Boring won't save you."

"No," Bree said, and her tongue felt dry. "But it buys time."

She dragged the sealed bundle toward the center of the rug - toward the open space where everyone could see it, where no one could pretend it was happening to someone else. Then she sat down hard, back straight, and kept Mr. Whiskers hugged to her chest like she was bracing for an exam she refused to fail.

Kenny exhaled, a sound that wasn't relief but calculation. "If they can't isolate you, they'll have to escalate."

Marcus stared at her like she'd broken the rules. "You're - "

"Waiting," Bree said, and felt the word settle in her like a new bone. Waiting wasn't weakness. Waiting was strategy.

Darla tried to move toward the corridor again, but Bree's body blocked it, and the house's vibration seemed to respond to attention - like it didn't know what to do with a choice that wasn't dramatic.

Jerome's shoulders lowered a fraction. Charlene's imagined heat steadied him. He stepped closer, not to take over Bree's moment, but to stand where Darla couldn't reach her without making herself the villain in front of everyone.

The speakers crackled, and Jenna's voice returned, louder now that the house had gotten what it wanted: a public target.

"Platinum Package reveal," Jenna said, and her tone made it sound like she was reading a menu. "The group will counter the donation loop by using the same channel to - "

Phil's laugh cut in. "By the way, that's adorable."

The speakers kept going anyway, unforgiving.

" - but the Platinum cost is communal. One action buys one outcome. The rest of the house pays the difference."

Bree felt cold spread through her arms. Communal cost meant she couldn't protect everyone with a single sacrifice. It meant the win she'd bought - saving them from the immediate major punishment - came with a bill that would land on all of them, right before the next escalation.

Darla's eyes flicked from Bree to the others, calculating who would resent her for not getting the corner, who would blame Bree for taking the hit. Marcus's fists unclenched, then clenched again, anger turning inward. Jerome looked like he was swallowing glass to keep from crying in public.

And Jenna's voice, cheerful as a guillotine, ended on one last promise of worse.

"Platinum Package still in effect," Jenna said. "Next donation route will be larger. Cameras will remain live."

Bree held Mr. Whiskers until her knuckles went pale, staring at the sealed bundle like it might confess what it was. She'd broken the immediate loop - she'd denied the

house its clean, isolating punishment, denied Darla her easy victory, denied herself the urge to panic.

But the house didn't care about her intention.

It cared about what she'd just proven: that the group could counter the system.

Which meant the system would get smarter.

And it would charge them for teaching it.

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Living Hell: Season Two

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First Edition: September 2026